

Healthy People 2030 (in 2026), Quality of Housing

Literature Summary & References | Source: odphp.health.gov

About This Literature Summary

This summary of the literature on Quality of Housing as a social determinant of health is a narrowly defined examination that is not intended to be exhaustive and may not address all dimensions of the issue. Please note: The terminology used in each summary is consistent with the respective references. For additional information on cross-cutting topics, please see the [Crime and Violence](#) , [Environmental Conditions](#) , and [Housing Instability](#) literature summaries.

Related Objectives (4)

Here's a snapshot of the objectives related to topics covered in this literature summary. [Browse all objectives](#) .

- [Increase the proportion of homes that have an entrance without steps — DH-04](#)
- [Reduce blood lead levels in children aged 1 to 5 years — EH-04](#)
- [Increase the proportion of people whose water systems have the recommended amount of fluoride — OH-11](#)
- [Increase the proportion of smoke-free homes — TU-18](#)

Related Evidence-Based Resources (3)

Here's a snapshot of the evidence-based resources related to topics covered in this literature summary. [Browse all evidence-based resources](#) .

- [A Healthy Home for Everyone: A Guide for Families and Individuals](#)
- [The Health Consequences of Involuntary Exposure to Tobacco Smoke: A Report of the Surgeon General](#)
- [The Surgeon General's Call To Action To Promote Healthy Homes](#)



Healthy People 2030 organizes the social determinants of health into 5 domains:

1. Economic Stability
2. Education Access and Quality
3. Health Care Access and Quality
4. Neighborhood and Built Environment

5. Social and Community Context

Literature Summary

There are several aspects to housing that impact health, including affordability, stability, quality and safety, and surrounding neighborhood.¹ This summary will discuss the quality of housing, specifically the physical quality of housing and neighborhood conditions. In this summary, “home” is used as an umbrella term to include all different types of dwellings, such as single-family homes and apartments. Housing quality refers to the physical conditions of a person’s home as well as the quality of the social and physical environment in which the home is located.^{2, 3} Poor-quality housing is associated with various negative health outcomes.^{3 - 6}

Home design and structure significantly influence housing quality and may affect both mental and physical health.^{7 - 9} Poor housing quality and inadequate conditions — such as the presence of lead, mold, or asbestos, poor air quality, and overcrowding — can contribute to negative health outcomes, including chronic disease and injury.^{2 - 6} For example, lead exposure from paint, pipes, and faucets can lead to irreversible adverse health effects.^{10 - 13} Even low levels of lead exposure can have serious effects on children’s health and behavior, including nervous system and cognitive development.^{14, 15} Lack of air conditioning and heating can affect residents’ health.^{3, 4, 16} Cold indoor conditions have been associated with high blood pressure and respiratory conditions, as well as depression.^{4, 17} Additionally, water leaks are associated with mold growth, which has been shown to affect respiratory health and increase the likelihood of asthma, coughing, and wheezing.^{18, 19} Lack of smoke alarms, carbon monoxide detectors, and other fire suppression requirements can lead to injury and death.¹ Lastly, residents of overcrowded homes may be at risk for poor mental health, food insecurity, and infectious diseases.^{3, 10, 20, 21}

Physical and structural housing conditions discussed above disproportionately impact children, older adults, individuals with physical disabilities, and low-income individuals.^{10, 22, 23} Children’s behaviors, such as hand-to-mouth activity, may increase their exposure to home pollutants that may influence growth and development.^{10, 22, 24} Older adults may experience serious injury from falls in the home, especially in homes with stairs, narrow doorways, or other obstacles.^{2, 4, 25} Steps, balconies, and windows are features of home design that may present a threat to safety, especially for individuals with physical disabilities.^{2, 3, 26}

In addition, low-income families may be more likely to live in older homes and homes with greater risks that can impact health outcomes.¹ For example, these homes may be under-insulated, lack air conditioning, and cost more to heat, leaving homes too hot or too cold, which has been linked to poorer health outcomes.^{3, 4, 16} Additionally, limited finances may result in a lack of housing maintenance, which can lead to poor housing conditions inside the

home (e.g., damaged appliances, exposed nails, or peeling paint) as well as outside the home (e.g., damage to stairs and windows).⁶

The quality of a house's neighborhood is shaped in part by how well individual homes are maintained, and widespread residential deterioration in a neighborhood can negatively affect mental health.⁶ In addition to housing quality, physical, social, and economic conditions within neighborhoods can also impact short- and long-term health outcomes.²⁷ These conditions may include crime and violence, environmental conditions, and access to public services such as public transportation, law enforcement, and schools. As a result, poor-quality housing in disadvantaged neighborhoods further exacerbates health disparities.²⁷

Addressing the quality of housing as a public health issue may help prevent and reduce negative health outcomes. Housing codes and laws, such as banning the use of lead paint, have led to increased quality of housing.^{3, 10} Additionally, local building codes and state statutes require landlords to provide basic standards such as sufficient hot water, reliable heat, and smoke and carbon monoxide detectors.²⁸ Programs such as the federal government's Housing Choice Voucher program assist vulnerable populations in securing quality housing. Landlords are required to pass the program's housing quality standards to provide decent, safe, and sanitary housing.²⁹ Further research is needed to develop other effective interventions to improve housing quality. This additional evidence will facilitate public health efforts to address quality of housing as a social determinant of health.

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